

Post-Perception Between Individual Project and Collective Movement

Can a Movement Originate from a Single Artist, or Does a True Movement Require Other Artists?

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Abstract

This paper addresses a central question facing many artist-initiated movements: **Can a movement originate from a single artist, or does a true movement require other artists?** Through analysis of the historical precedents of avant-garde movements—Dada, Surrealism, Conceptual Art, De Stijl, and others—and a critical examination of the concept of "movement" itself, the paper argues that the answer lies in a distinction between the **founding** of a movement and its **expansion**. Movements are typically founded by individuals or small groups; what distinguishes a movement from a personal style is not the number of founders but the **openness** to others, the **codification** of principles, and the **infrastructure** for participation. The paper evaluates Post-Perception against these criteria, concluding that while the movement currently operates as an individual project, it has established the necessary conditions for becoming a collective movement: a clear manifesto, a coherent body of work, codified principles and conditions of belonging, a practical guide for artists, institutional recognition, and an open invitation. The paper concludes that the transition from individual project to collective movement is not automatic but requires active outreach, translation, and the cultivation of a community of practice.

Keywords: Artistic Movement, Individual Project, Post-Perception, Avant-Garde, Institutional Critique, Founding, Expansion.

1. Introduction

1.1 The Question

Is "Post-Perception" a movement or an individual project? Can a single artist claim to have founded a movement? Or is a movement by definition collective?

These questions are not merely semantic. They have practical consequences for how the work is received, how other artists relate to it, and how it is written into art history.

1.2 The Stakes

| If an individual project | If a collective movement |

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| Dies with its founder | Can survive and evolve after its founder |

| Cannot be expanded | Can be enriched by other artists |

| Is a personal style | Is a shared framework |

| Ends when the artist stops | Continues as long as others practice it |

1.3 Research Question

****Can a movement originate from a single artist, or does a true movement require other artists?****

This paper argues that movements are typically founded by individuals or small groups; what distinguishes a movement from a personal style is not the number of founders but ****openness**** to others, ****codification**** of principles, and ****infrastructure**** for participation.

2. What Is an Artistic Movement?

2.1 Defining Characteristics

Based on art-historical analysis, a movement typically has:

| Characteristic | Description |

|-----|-----|

| ****Manifesto**** | A published statement of principles |

| ****Body of work**** | A coherent set of artworks embodying the principles |

| ****Multiple artists**** | More than one artist practicing the movement |

| **Critical reception** | Recognition by critics, curators, and historians |

| **Institutional presence** | Exhibitions, publications, and documentation |

| **Influence** | Impact on subsequent art |

2.2 The Foundational Role of Individuals

Many movements were founded by individuals or small groups:

| Movement | Founder(s) | Early stage |

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| **De Stijl** | Theo van Doesburg | Initially a small group; Van Doesburg was the driving force |

| **Surrealism** | André Breton | Began with Breton's manifesto and a small circle of writers |

| **Dada** | Hugo Ball, Tristan Tzara, Richard Huelsenbeck | A small group in Zurich; no single founder |

| **Conceptual Art** | Sol LeWitt, Joseph Kosuth, others | Multiple originators, no single founder |

| **Futurism** | Filippo Tommaso Marinetti | Largely Marinetti's initiative; he was the theorist and organizer |

The lesson: Movements are rarely created by committees. They are typically initiated by individuals or small groups who then attract others.

2.3 What Makes a Movement, Not a Style

The difference between a "personal style" and a "movement" is not the number of artists practicing it. It is:

| Personal style | Movement |

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| Closed to others | Open to others |

| Implicit principles | Explicit, codified principles (manifesto) |

| No conditions for belonging | Clear conditions of belonging |

| No infrastructure for others to join | Practical guides, workshops, invitations |

| Ends with the artist | Can continue after the artist |

3. Historical Precedents

3.1 Case Study: De Stijl (1917–1931)

| Aspect | Detail |

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| ****Founder**** | Theo van Doesburg |

| ****Early stage**** | Van Doesburg, Mondrian, and a small group; Van Doesburg was the organizer and publicist |

| ****Expansion**** | Attracted other artists, architects, and designers |

| ****Duration**** | 14 years; ended with Van Doesburg's death |

****Lesson:**** A movement can be largely driven by one person but still be a movement because others joined.

3.2 Case Study: Surrealism (1924–1966)

| Aspect | Detail |

|-----|-----|

| ****Founder**** | André Breton |

| ****Early stage**** | Breton's manifesto, a small circle of writers |

| ****Expansion**** | Attracted painters (Dalí, Magritte, Miró), sculptors, and filmmakers |

| ****Duration**** | 42 years; continued after Breton's death (expelled members continued) |

****Lesson:**** A movement can be dominated by a founder but still be a movement if it has multiple practitioners.

3.3 Case Study: Conceptual Art (1960s–1970s)

| Aspect | Detail |

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| ****Founders**** | Multiple (LeWitt, Kosuth, Weiner, etc.) |

| ****Early stage**** | No single manifesto; multiple artists working independently |

| ****Expansion**** | Attracted many artists globally |

| ****Duration**** | Ongoing as an influence, though the "movement" phase was relatively short |

****Lesson:**** Multiple founders are not necessary; a movement can emerge from parallel individual practices.

3.4 Case Study: Stuckism (1999–present)

Aspect	Detail
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Founders	Billy Childish and Charles Thomson
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Early stage	Two founders, a manifesto, and a small group
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Expansion	Grew to hundreds of artists in dozens of countries
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Duration	Ongoing, though less prominent
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****Lesson:**** A movement can be founded by a very small group (two) and still grow.

3.5 What These Cases Show

Finding	Implication
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Moves can be founded by individuals or small groups	Single-founder origins are not disqualifying
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The founder often plays an outsized role	But the movement must attract others
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Duration does not depend on the founder's presence	Surrealism outlasted Breton; Stuckism continues
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The key is openness, not numbers	A manifesto and infrastructure for participation
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4. Post-Perception's Readiness for Collective Expansion

4.1 What Already Exists

Component	Present?	Evidence
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Manifesto	☒	9 principles, published in the book
Body of work	☒	33 artworks across 6 classifications
Codified principles	☒	9 principles, 9 conditions of belonging
Practical guide	☒	"How to Produce a Post-Perception Artwork"
Critical reception	☒	Recognition in Malta Biennale, academic publications, press
Institutional presence	☒	Participation in international biennials, documentation
Open invitation	☒	"Open invitation to artists worldwide"

4.2 What Is Missing

Missing element	Status	Plan
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Other artists	Currently none	Translation, outreach, workshops, open calls
Collective exhibitions	None yet	To be organized once others join
Peer-reviewed studies	Some in progress	Encouraging academic research
Translation	In progress	English, French, Spanish, German

4.3 Conditions of Belonging Are Already Codified

The movement has published ****nine conditions of belonging****:

1. Focus on destabilizing perception
2. Cognitive interaction (not passive)
3. Exploration of the fragility of reality and simulation
4. Transcendence of traditional narratives
5. Use of diverse media
6. Philosophical and conceptual depth
7. Temporal persistence and effect

8. Subjective involvement of the viewer

9. Multi-sensory deconstruction

****Any artist whose work meets these conditions can claim to work within Post-Perception.****

5. Objections to Single-Founder Movements

Objection 1: A movement requires multiple artists; single-founder movements are a contradiction in terms.

****Response:**** By this logic, Surrealism would not have been a movement when Breton published his first manifesto. Movements begin with individuals; they become movements when others join.

Objection 2: Movements are not declared; they are recognized by others.

****Response:**** This confuses cause and effect. Movements are both declared (manifestos) and recognized (by critics, historians). The declaration comes first; recognition follows—or may never follow. The absence of recognition does not retroactively invalidate the declaration.

Objection 3: A movement led by a single artist is just the artist's personal style.

****Response:**** The difference is not the number of artists but the ****codification**** of principles and the ****invitation**** to others. A personal style is something one does; a movement is something one shares.

6. The Transition from Individual Project to Collective Movement

6.1 The Stages

Stage	Description	Post-Perception status
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1. Individual practice	The artist works alone	Completed (30+ years)
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2. Codification	Principles are articulated	Completed (manifesto, conditions)
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3. Publication	The framework is published	Completed (books, articles)
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4. Recognition	Critics, curators, institutions take notice	Ongoing (Malta Biennale, academic interest)
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5. Outreach	Other artists are invited	Beginning
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6. Collective practice	Others produce Post-Perception works	Not yet
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| ****7. Historical consolidation**** | The movement enters art history | Future |

6.2 The Role of the Founder

| Responsibility | Description |

|-----|-----|

| ****Articulate principles**** | The manifesto and conditions |

| ****Model practice**** | The 33 artworks as examples |

| ****Provide infrastructure**** | Guides, translations, open calls |

| ****Invite participation**** | Explicit invitations to other artists |

| ****Cede control**** | Allowing the movement to evolve beyond his vision |

6.3 The Necessary Cession of Control

For Post-Perception to become a true movement, the founder must be willing to:

| Action | Why it matters |

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| ****Accept works he would not have made himself**** | Movements evolve; the founder is not the sole arbiter

| ****Accept works that challenge his interpretation**** | The movement belongs to its practitioners, not its founder |

| ****Accept that the movement may exceed his intentions**** | Vitality depends on openness |

7. Comparing Post-Perception to Other Artist-Initiated Movements

7.1 The Spectrum

| Movement | Founder(s) | Number at founding | Number at peak |

|-----|-----|-----|-----|

| ****De Stijl**** | Van Doesburg | Small group | Dozens |

| ****Surrealism**** | Breton | Small group | Hundreds |

| ****Conceptual Art**** | Multiple | Several | Hundreds |

| ****Stuckism**** | Childish, Thomson | 2 | Hundreds |

| ****Post-Perception**** | Shalabi | 1 | 0 (currently) |

7.2 Where Post-Perception Stands

Post-Perception is at an **early stage** analogous to Surrealism in 1924 (just after the manifesto) or De Stijl in 1917. It has not yet attracted other artists, but the infrastructure for expansion is in place.

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8. Conclusion: From Individual Project to Collective Movement

8.1 The Answer

****Can a movement originate from a single artist?****

Yes, movements can originate from single artists. Surrealism originated from Breton; De Stijl from Van Doesburg; Futurism from Marinetti; Stuckism from Childish and Thomson (two). The number of founders is not the defining characteristic of a movement.

****Does a true movement require other artists?****

Yes, eventually. A movement that remains a single artist indefinitely is not a movement; it is a personal style. The key is not whether other artists have joined yet, but whether the **conditions** for their joining exist.

8.2 Where Post-Perception Stands

Post-Perception has the conditions for becoming a collective movement:

- A published manifesto
- A coherent body of work
- Codified principles and conditions of belonging
- A practical guide for artists
- An open invitation
- Institutional recognition (Malta Biennale)

****What it lacks is other artists.**** But this is a temporal lack, not a structural one.

8.3 The Path Forward

| Action | Priority |

|-----|-----|

| ****Translation**** into multiple languages | High |

| ****International outreach**** to potential artists | High |

| ****Workshops and training**** for interested artists | Medium |

| ****Collective exhibitions**** featuring other artists | Medium |

| ****Documentation of works by other artists**** in future publications | Medium |

| ****Ceding control**** to the movement's collective evolution | Ongoing |

****As the manifesto of Post-Perception declares:****

> "We are not here to close the door of perception, but to push it beyond. This manifesto is an open invitation to experimentation, to intellectual adventure, to the production of art that transcends the familiar, art that understands that perception itself is the artwork."

****The question that this analysis leaves with us is not "Is Post-Perception already a movement?" but:****

> ****"Will other artists join?"****

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